How to Play Cricket

A simple guide for beginners

1. What is cricket?

Cricket is a bat-and-ball game played between two teams of 11 players. One team bats and tries to score runs. The other team bowls and fields and tries to get the batters out. Then the teams swap. The team with more runs at the end wins.

2. The ground and equipment

The game is played on a large grass field. In the middle is a flat strip called the **pitch**. At each end of the pitch stand the **wickets**, which are three wooden stumps with two small bails on top.

You need: a hard ball, a flat wooden bat, wickets, and pads and gloves to protect the batters. Always use a helmet when facing fast bowling.

3. The two sides

Batting team: two batters are on the pitch at a time, one at each end. They score runs by hitting the ball and running between the wickets.

Fielding team: one player bowls, one player (the wicketkeeper) stands behind the wickets, and the others spread out around the field to stop runs and catch the ball.

4. How the game starts

The captains toss a coin. The winner chooses to bat first or to bowl first. Then the first bowler delivers the ball to the batter at the other end.

5. How to score runs

Running: after hitting the ball, both batters run to the opposite end. Each time they swap ends safely, they score 1 run.

Four: if the ball hits the ground and rolls over the boundary line, the batting team gets 4 runs.

Six: if the ball flies over the boundary line without bouncing, the batting team gets 6 runs.

Extras: if the bowler bowls a wide or a no-ball, the batting team gets a free run.

6. How a batter gets out

There are several ways, but these are the most common:

• **Bowled:** the ball hits the wickets.

• **Caught:** a fielder catches the ball before it bounces.

• **LBW (leg before wicket):** the ball hits the batter's leg and would have hit the wickets.

• **Run out:** the fielders hit the wickets with the ball before the batter reaches the line.

• **Stumped:** the wicketkeeper breaks the wickets while the batter is out of the crease.

7. Overs

The bowler bowls 6 balls in a row. This is called an **over**. After each over, a different bowler bowls from the other end, and the fielders change sides.

8. Match formats

T20: each team bats for 20 overs. A match takes about 3 hours.

One Day: each team bats for up to 50 overs. A match takes about 7 to 8 hours.

Test match: each team bats twice, with no limit on overs, over up to 5 days.

9. Tips for beginners

• Watch the ball all the way to the bat.

• Keep your head still and your eyes level when you bat.

• Bowl with a straight arm, and aim at the wickets.

• Call clearly when you run, so your partner knows if it is yes, no or wait.

• Respect the umpires and your opponents. Fair play is part of cricket.

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